How to Watch Your Brother Die

By Michael Lassell

INTRODUCTION

Every popular magazine today has them – Check lists. It seems so simple . . . just follow the steps and life will be easier & happier, relationships more fulfilling & exciting, your home will be organized, your children will raise themselves AND if you act now, you can save enough money by clipping coupons to take that vacation to Tahiti . . . It all sounds so easy. But let's face it. There are no easy answers to life's most difficult situations, no checklists to cover as you work through the traumas of life. You survive with God's Grace and learn by trial and error "How to Watch Your Brother Die" by Michael Lasso.

When the call comes, be calm.

Say to your wife, "My brother is dying. I have to fly to California."

Try not to be shocked that he already looks like a cadaver.

Say to the young man sitting by your brother's side,

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"I'm his brother."

Try not to be shocked when the young man says,

"I'm his lover. Thanks for coming."

Listen to the doctor with a steel face on.

Sign the necessary forms.

Tell the doctor you will take care of everything.

Wonder why doctors are so remote.

Watch the lover's eyes as they stare into

your brother's eyes as they stare into

space

Wonder what they see there.

Remember the time he was jealous and

opened your eyebrow with a sharp stick.

Forgive him out loud

even if he can't

understand you.

Realize the scar will be

all that's left of him.

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Over coffee in the hospital cafeteria
say to the lover, "You're an extremely good-looking
young man."
Hear him say,
"I never thought I was good enough looking to
deserve your brother."

Watch the tears well up in his eyes. Say,
"I'm sorry. I don't know what it means to be
the lover of another man."
Hear him say,
"It's just like a wife, only the commitment is
deeper because the odds against you are so much
greater."
Say nothing, but
take his hand like a brother's.

Drive to Mexico for unproven drugs that might
help him live longer.
Explain what they are to the border guard.

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Fill with rage when he informs you,
"You can't bring those across."
Begin to grow loud.
Feel the lover's hand on your arm
restraining you. See in the guard's eye
how much a man can hate another man.
Say to the lover, "How can you stand it?"
Hear him say, "You get used to it."
Think of one of your children getting used to
another man's hatred.

Call your wife on the telephone. Tell her,
"He hasn't much time.
I'll be home soon." Before you hang up say,
"How could anyone's commitment be deeper than
a husband and wife?" Hear her say,
"Please. I don't want to know all the details."

When he slips into an irrevocable coma,
hold his lover in your arms while he sobs,

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no longer strong. Wonder how much longer
you will be able to be strong.
Feel how it feels to hold a man in your arms
whose arms are used to holding men.
Offer God anything to bring your brother back.
Know you have nothing God could possibly want.
Curse God, but do not
abandon Him.

Stare at the face of the funeral director
when he tells you he will not
embalm the body for fear of
contamination. Let him see in your eyes
how much a man can hate another man.

Stand beside a casket covered in flowers,
white flowers. Say,
"Thank you for coming," to each of several hundred
men
who file past in tears, some of them

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holding hands. Know your brother's life
was not what you imagined. Overhear two
mourners say, "I wonder who'll be next?" and
"I don't care anymore,
as long as it isn't you."

Arrange to take an early flight home.
His lover will drive you to the airport.
When your flight is announced say,
awkwardly, "If I can do anything, please
let me know." Do not flinch when he says,
"Forgive yourself for not wanting to know him
after he told you. He did."
Stop and let it soak in. Say,
"He forgave me, or he knew himself?"
"Both," the lover will say, not knowing what else
to do. Hold him like a brother while he
kisses you on the cheek. Think that
you haven't been kissed by a man since

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your father died. Think,

"This is no moment not to be strong."

Fly first class and drink Scotch. Stroke

your split eyebrow with a finger and

think of your brother alive. Smile

at the memory and think

how your children will feel in your arms,

warm and friendly and without challenge.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Michael Lassell
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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
Colorado State Finalist
KS State Qualifier

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